prised approximately seventy-five grottoes and caves in the foothills surrounding a group of structures, a free-standing building among the latter interests us here. This brick structure with rubble footing was square on plan, having near-circular towers diagonally addorsed at the corners, and hemispherical towers centered in three of the four walls (Figures 3.19 and 3.20). Probably double-storied, it was configured around a courtyard with four *ivan*s, the one on the southeast also serving as a monumental entrance. Adjacent to this entrance on its north was a corner chamber with a *mihrab* in its western wall (Figure 3.21). Though missing the top, the remaining niche had a flat (rather than hemispherical) back wall, whose stucco revetment was replete with interlaced hexagons and six-pointed stars (Figure 3.22). Each of the shapes was filled in with stylized floral, vegetal, and circular motifs, in turn pierced with numerous holes to create a visual play of voids and solids, light and shadow. Although M. Le Berre expressed surprise at finding "in a monument of the Islamic period the half-wall of diaper-masonry so characteristic of the Buddhist monuments of Afghanistan and the pre-Islamic monuments of the central Hindu Kush," archaeologists have favored an eleventh- or twelfth-century date for the structure as a whole, based on the presence of this *mihrab* and its stucco decoration.[64]

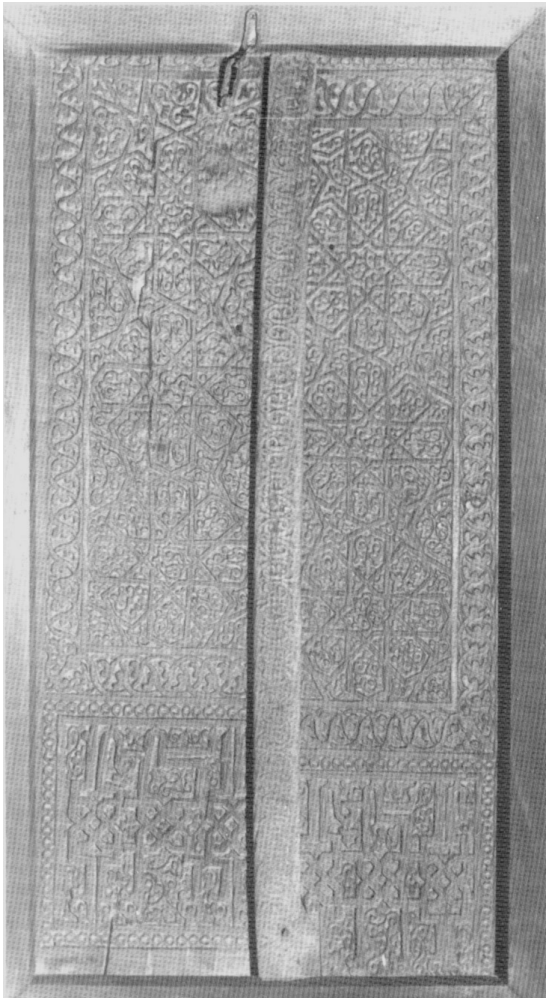


Figure 3.13 *Shahr-i Gholghola, recovered wooden door leaves (whereabouts unknown). From Baker and Allchin 1996: 31.*

Given its proximity to the major Buddhist and possibly Western Turk dynastic center of Bamiyan itself (cf. above), and in light of the abundance of surviving pre-Islamic structures throughout the area, it is not impossible that Danestama was originally a pre-Islamic site, repurposed during the twelfth century. We know, of course, that the continuation of building practices despite political changes was consistent with the nature of architectural cultures (see Introduction), so that brick walls upon rubble